

RAKUTEN SHOPIFY × IMPACT.COM POC — PILLAR 3

The Exclusive Access Journey A Walkthrough of the Design

Not a screen-by-screen tour — a walk through the design decisions behind the exclusive-access member journey: what problem each moment solves, why it's built the way it is, and what it needs to prove for the executive demo to hold up.

Synthetic data only. Prototypes are static HTML/CSS/JS — no backend, no real Shopify or Impact.com connection.

Prepared for internal review ahead of the Aug 14, 2026 executive demo.

Contents

01 The Question This Walkthrough Answers

02 Act I — Being Recognized, Not Marketed To

03 Act II — The Riskiest Moment: Leaving Rakuten

04 Act III — Proving It Wasn't Just a Coupon

05 Act IV — Closing the Loop

06 Grounding the Illusion — Why the Merchant Site Had to Look Real

07 One Flow, Three Reasons to Use It

08 What This Walkthrough Doesn't Decide

Every screen in this walkthrough exists in three places: a Rakuten mobile app frame, a Rakuten desktop site, and an independent merchant's Shopify storefront. The screenshots below are drawn mostly from the desktop path, since it reads clearest in print — the interactive prototypes at </demos> let you replay the same journey on mobile, or with either checkout mechanism.

The Question This Walkthrough Answers

Not "what does the screen look like" — "what has to be true for this to be believed as real"

Pillar 3 makes one specific claim: **a product can be made exclusively available through Rakuten, and Rakuten can prove — not just assert — that it was the reason the sale happened.** Everything in this walkthrough exists to make that claim demonstrable in a live room, not just plausible on a slide.

That claim has three separate things that all have to hold up, and each one maps to a section below:

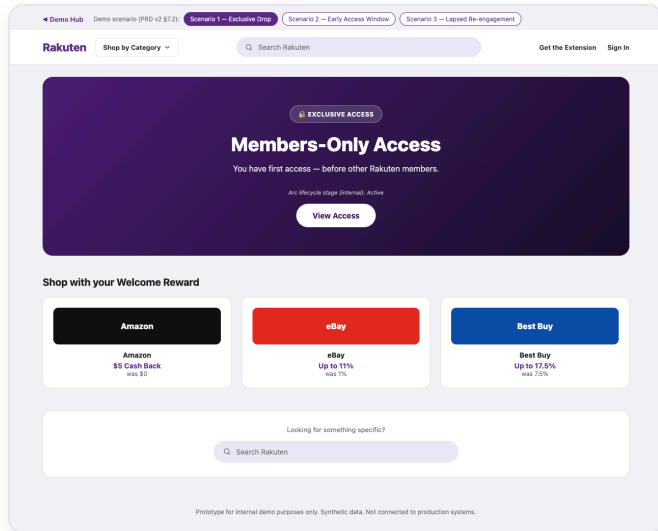
What has to be true	Where it's tested in the journey
The offer has to feel like it was <i>selected for this member</i> , not a generic coupon with an "exclusive" sticker slapped on	Act I — the entry point and offer detail screens
The member has to trust the handoff from Rakuten's site to a merchant's site enough to actually buy — and the product genuinely has to be unreachable any other way	Act II & III — the redirect and the merchant's own storefront
Rakuten has to be able to show, not tell, that it gets credit for the sale	Act IV — the return trip and attribution proof

Why this matters beyond the demo: this POC's actual output isn't the demo itself — it's the **build vs. buy recommendation** it feeds. If any of these three things breaks or feels fake in the room, it doesn't just hurt Pillar 3 — it weakens the argument that Rakuten can build this in-house at all.

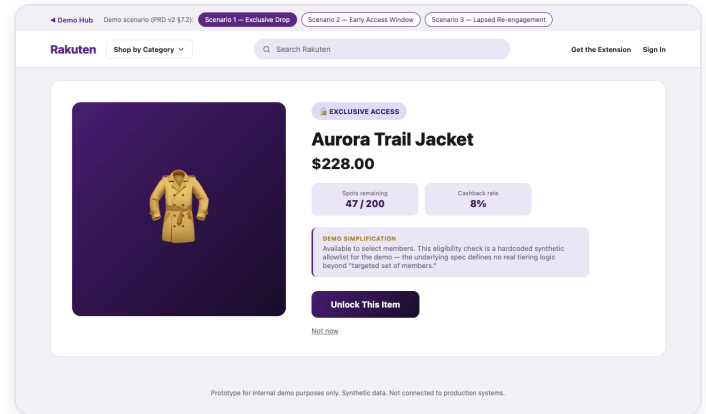
Being Recognized, Not Marketed To

The design problem: how do you make an offer feel like it was chosen for you?

The spec never tells us where this offer should live on rakuten.com — that placement decision was open, and this prototype answers it. The choice made here: put it in the same visual slot as Rakuten's existing promo cards (the "StubHub — Shop today's Big Deal" pattern already on Home), but break every visual convention that slot normally follows.



Home — the exclusive card sits where a normal cashback promo would



Offer detail — countdown, cashback rate, and an honest caveat about eligibility

That's deliberate: a normal cashback card is purple; this one is a purple-to-black gradient with a lock glyph. A member scanning the page shouldn't have to read the copy to know this is a different kind of offer — the acceptance criterion behind this (US-1) literally requires the exclusive offer be "distinguishable from a standard cashback offer," and the fastest way to satisfy that for a room full of people watching a demo is visual, not textual.

The eligibility line does something the spec doesn't ask for

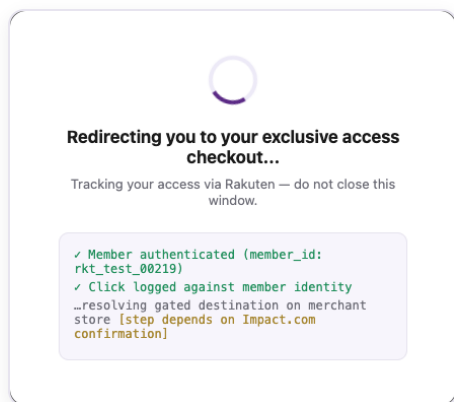
Notice the "DEMO SIMPLIFICATION" flag under the eligibility copy on the offer detail screen. The real spec has no tiering logic — it just says "targeted set of members." Rather than inventing a fake tiering system that could get mistaken for a real product decision later, the prototype names its own shortcut out loud. That's a small thing, but it's the difference between a demo that misleads people about what's built versus one that's honest about what's still a placeholder.

What this act has to prove: a member looking at this for three seconds knows it's not a regular deal — without reading a word of body copy.

The Riskiest Moment: Leaving Rakuten

The design problem: the member is about to leave a platform they trust for a merchant site they've never seen

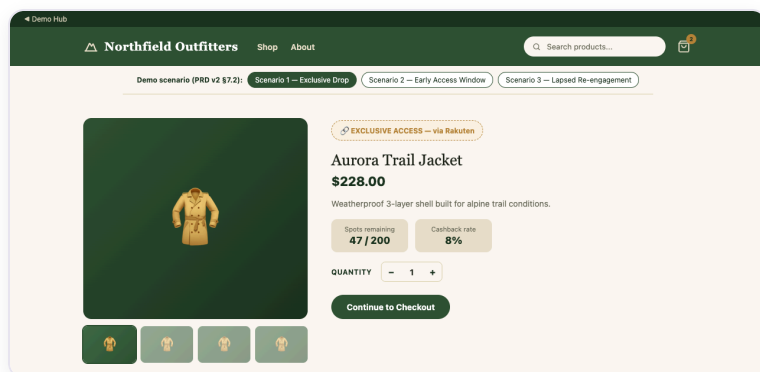
This is the single moment in the whole journey with the highest chance of losing the person — a member clicks "Unlock This Item" on rakuten.com and, a beat later, they're standing on a storefront called Northfield Outfitters that they've never heard of, with no Rakuten branding anywhere. If that transition feels like a bait-and-switch, the trust the exclusivity offer built in Act I evaporates immediately.



Two things happen here that would otherwise be invisible: the member sees their own click get logged against their identity, and the prototype names the one part that isn't confirmed yet — *whether a click can trigger a synchronous action before the redirect completes*, the single highest-leverage open question with Impact.com. Showing it on screen means whoever's presenting can say "this is the part we're validating" instead of hoping nobody asks.

Arriving on a site that looks nothing like Rakuten — on purpose

Northfield Outfitters uses a completely different palette (forest green and tan, serif logotype) from every Rakuten-branded screen here. That's the whole point of the merchant surface existing as its own prototype instead of a purple-tinted mock: it demonstrates that Rakuten can extend access *onto someone else's storefront* and still get the credit, without needing to own or rebrand it.



The gated product page — reachable only via the link Rakuten issued, not by browsing

What has to actually be true, not just look true: searching Northfield's own site for "Aurora Trail Jacket" should return nothing — a gated product that's secretly still findable through normal search isn't exclusive, it's just unlinked. Tested directly in the prototype's negative case.

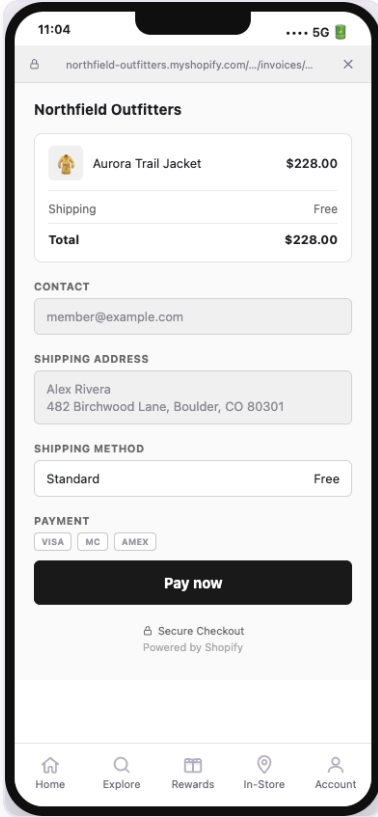
Proving It Wasn't Just a Coupon

The design problem: a discount code looks the same whether it's exclusive or not — so how do you make the exclusivity itself visible at checkout?

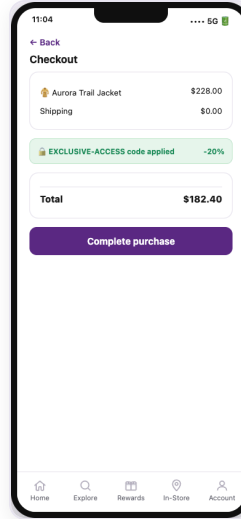
By the time a member reaches checkout, the interesting design question isn't "does the discount apply" — Shopify already does that reliably. It's whether the *mechanism* that got them there survives scrutiny. This prototype builds both of the two mechanisms the spec left undecided, on purpose, because the honest answer right now is "it isn't yet confirmed which one Impact.com's platform actually supports."

Mechanism	What it feels like to buy	What it risks
A — Draft-order invoice link	A genuine Shopify-hosted invoice checkout — the member visibly leaves the app for an in-app browser showing the merchant's own checkout domain, no cart step, just "Pay now"	Doesn't look like a normal in-app purchase — could feel unfamiliar to a first-time buyer
B — Shared link + single-use code	A normal product page with a code auto-applied at checkout	Looks completely ordinary — which is exactly why it's the safer choice for a live exec demo

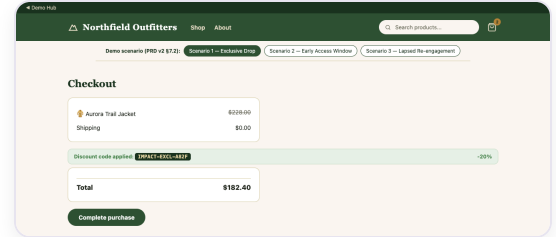
The mobile prototype lets you toggle between them live. Variant A is grounded in what a draft-order invoice checkout actually is — a hosted webpage on the merchant's own Shopify domain, not an in-app screen — so it's wrapped in an in-app-browser chrome around a genuinely Shopify-styled checkout: merchant wordmark, muted prefilled fields, card-brand icons, a "Powered by Shopify" footer, none of it Rakuten-branded. The design's recommendation (not a final decision — that's Impact.com's call, pending the sync-click question from Act II) is that Variant B reads as more familiar in a room, because it looks like nothing unusual is happening — the exclusivity already did its job upstream.



Variant A — a real Shopify-hosted invoice checkout, reached via an in-app browser



Variant B — code pre-applied, in-app



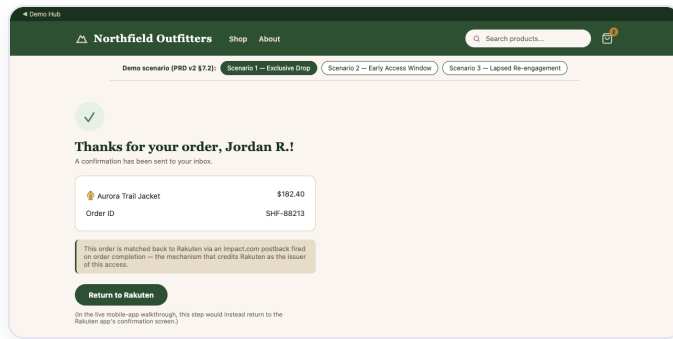
Variant B's mechanism on the merchant desktop site — \$228 → \$182.40, single-use

What this act has to prove: the purchase itself feels ordinary — all the "exclusive" work already happened before this screen.

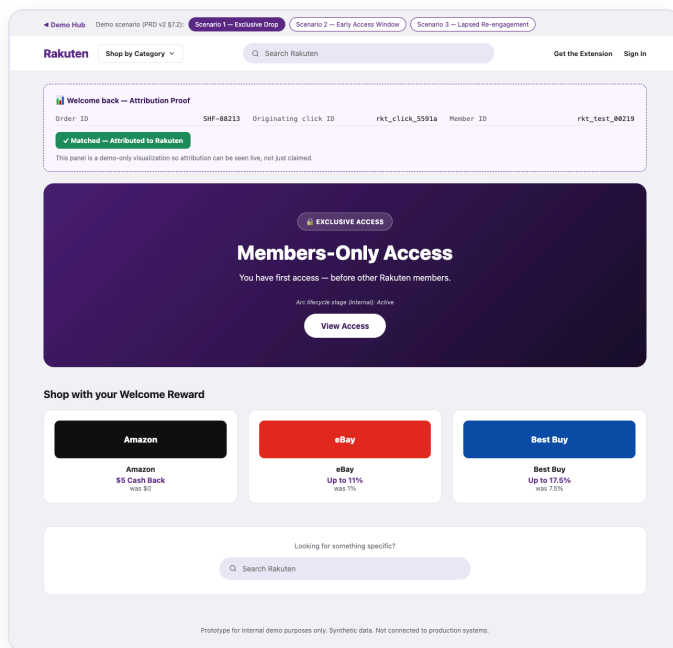
Closing the Loop

The design problem: attribution is invisible by nature — how do you make it visible, not just claimed?

This is the section that most directly answers the Aug 14 success criterion for Pillar 3: *"a hidden product accessible only via a Rakuten-issued unique link/code; attribution correctly credits Rakuten."* The first half — hidden, unique link — is what Acts II and III demonstrated. This is where the second half gets proven.



On the merchant's own confirmation screen, a single inline note explains — in the exact language the underlying spec uses — that Impact.com's postback is a one-way, after-the-fact notification, not a synchronous handshake. That's a deliberate refusal to overstate what's confirmed: it would be easy to write copy that implies real-time certainty here, and this doesn't.



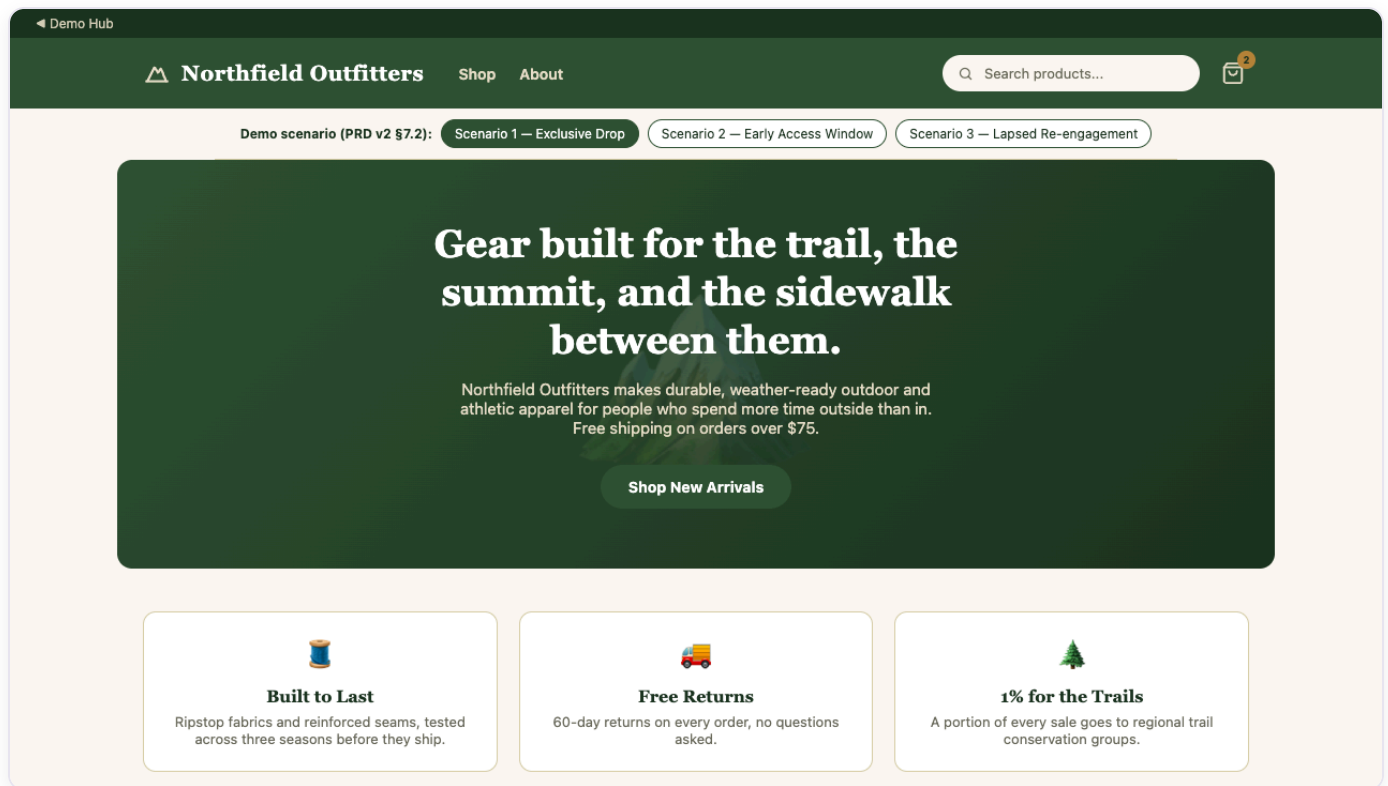
Back on rakuten.com, a "Welcome back" panel shows the order ID, the click ID from Act II, and the member ID, laid side by side with a "Matched ✓" badge. No real member would ever see this screen — it exists purely so whoever is running the demo can point at three IDs lining up and say "there's the match," instead of narrating an invisible backend process and asking the room to take it on faith.

Why this specific design choice matters for the build-vs-buy argument: a demo that only *describes* attribution ("trust us, it's tracked") gives reviewers nothing to evaluate. A demo that *shows the match* gives them something concrete to ask follow-up questions about — which IDs, which system, how reliable — and those are exactly the questions the eventual build-vs-buy decision needs answered.

Grounding the Illusion — Why the Merchant Site Had to Look Real

A prototype that looks like a mockup teaches the room the wrong lesson

An earlier version of this prototype leaned on decoration that didn't survive scrutiny: a bespoke merchant-site layout that didn't resemble any real e-commerce platform, and a Variant A checkout that stayed inside Rakuten's own visual language even though a real draft-order invoice is a page on the *merchant's* Shopify domain. Both of those were replaced with something closer to what actually exists today.



Northfield Outfitters, restructured around a real Shopify theme: header with cart icon, full-width hero, collection grid, multi-column footer

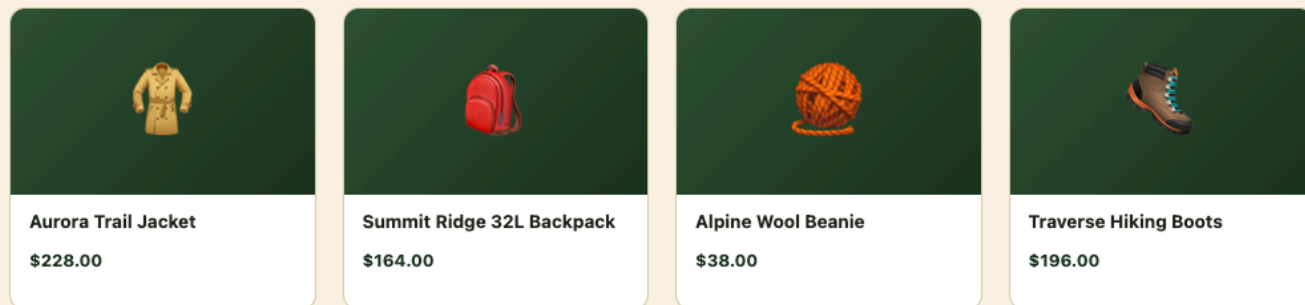
The merchant homepage now follows the structure of a real default Shopify theme rather than a one-off layout — a header with a cart icon and item count, a full-width hero banner, a product grid, and a proper multi-column footer with a newsletter block. None of this changes what the feature does; it changes whether a viewer believes the merchant side is a real, separate business rather than a Rakuten-controlled stage set.

A demo needs more than one thing to click on

The earlier prototype hardcoded a single SKU with a single entry point. This version adds three more products and surfaces all four as a browsable grid — but that grid is not, and should not be mistaken for, a real storefront feature.

DEMO ENTRY POINTS — NOT PART OF THE REAL CUSTOMER-FACING SURFACE

These products are hidden from Northfield's normal storefront browsing and search (per US-3) — a real shopper only ever reaches one via a Rakuten-issued link. This grid exists so the demo can be clicked through quickly, not to represent how customers would discover it.



The "Rakuten Exclusive" grid — clearly labeled as a demo convenience, not a real customer-facing surface

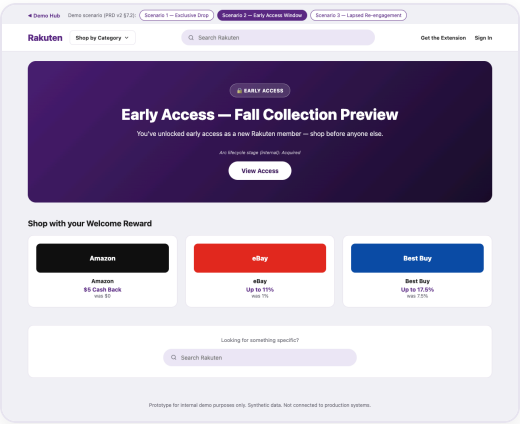
Why this grid is flagged, not hidden in the nav: the entire premise of Pillar 3 (per the spec's US-3) is that these products are invisible to normal storefront browsing — a real shopper only ever reaches one via a Rakuten-issued link. A public "Shop Exclusive" nav item would directly contradict that. The grid exists so whoever is running or reviewing the demo can move quickly between products; it is explicitly labeled as exactly that, so nobody mistakes it for the real discovery mechanism.

One Flow, Three Reasons to Use It

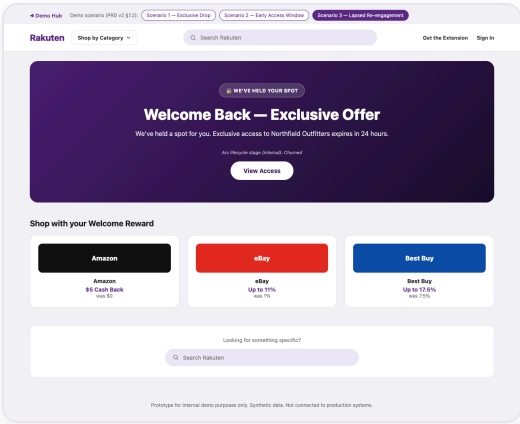
The same mechanics, three different business justifications for why Rakuten should send this offer at all

Everything in Acts I–IV describes the mechanical journey — offer, handoff, purchase, proof. But the same exclusivity mechanic is only valuable to a merchant if it's aimed at a member for a reason a merchant actually cares about. The same four screens play out differently depending on *why* Rakuten decided this member should see this offer:

Scenario	Who's being targeted	The merchant's actual question this answers
Exclusive Drop	An engaged member with category affinity — no prior relationship required	"Can you get me buyers I couldn't reach myself?"
Early Access Window	A newly acquired member, given first access as a welcome moment	"Can you make a new customer's first experience feel special?"
Lapsed Re-engagement	A member who bought before and went quiet 90+ days	"Can you bring back someone I've already lost?" — the sale that provably wouldn't have happened otherwise



Early Access — "goes public in 47 hours"



Lapsed Re-engagement — "we've held a spot for you"

Of the three, Lapsed Re-engagement is worth calling out specifically: it's the scenario the product PRD calls the "purest incrementality story," because there's no ambiguity about whether the sale was already going to happen. A member who's bought nothing in 90+ days, then buys the day after receiving this offer, is about as clean a causal story as a merchant is ever going to get — which is exactly the kind of proof point every feature in this product has to earn.

What This Walkthrough Doesn't Decide

Being clear about the difference between "designed" and "resolved"

Every prototype in this walkthrough is a UX reference, not a technical architecture. A few things it deliberately leaves open, and where they surface above:

Open question	Where it showed up above
Whether a click can trigger a synchronous action, not just an after-the-fact postback	Act II — flagged directly in the redirect trace
Which gating mechanism ships — invoice link vs. discount code	Act III — both built in parallel, a recommendation offered, no decision made
Whether Rakuten's member ID survives end-to-end through Impact.com's tracking parameters without collision	Act IV — assumed working in the demo; not actually validated against Impact.com's platform
Whether Impact.com has ever built anything like this for another publisher	Not shown — this walkthrough intentionally doesn't speculate about integration paths that aren't grounded in what's documented today

These aren't gaps in the demo — they're the actual open items in `impact-pillar3-spec.md` §2, carried through faithfully instead of quietly resolved for the sake of a cleaner story. The Impact.com conversation referenced elsewhere in the project is what should close most of these; this walkthrough is deliberately built so that whichever way those answers land, the member-facing design mostly doesn't need to change.

Full screen-by-screen reference and the live, clickable prototypes: `/demos`. Underlying spec: `impact-pillar3-spec.md`. Source PRD: `PRD_Exclusive_Early_Access_v2.html`.

Where to go from here

Every screen referenced in this walkthrough is a live, clickable prototype — open </demos/index.html> to replay any part of this journey yourself: switch checkout mechanisms, click through the "Rakuten Exclusive" product grid, or try a different demo scenario.

Underlying spec and design docs: [impact-pillar3-spec.md](#), [design/pillar-3-exclusive-access.md](#), [PRD_Exclusive_Early_Access_v2.html](#).

Rakuten Rewards — Pillar 3 POC — Internal demo prototype, synthetic data only.